

Trade & Vocational Skills in Highest Demand in Ireland

The Next 24–36 Months

Demand drivers: housing targets · retrofit obligations · energy transition · automation displacement · demographic shifts

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The Big Picture

Ireland's situation is unusual in that all five drivers point in the same direction rather than competing. The demographic squeeze, the housing gap, retrofit, and the grid and energy buildout all draw on an overlapping pool of trades, while automation is simultaneously hollowing out the office-based alternatives that might otherwise compete for the same workers. That compounding effect is the key thing to understand before looking at any individual trade.

The scale of the shortfall is the backdrop. The construction workforce sits at roughly 177,600, about 54,400 below its 2007 peak, and the sector will need to add between 95,000 and 110,000 additional workers to meet Government housing targets. Build Up Skills research puts the figure even higher when retrofit and energy are included: up to 120,000 additional recruits plus retraining for 164,000 already employed by 2030. Critically, the pipeline is moving the wrong way — construction apprenticeship completions fell 14% in 2024, which is why these shortages will persist well beyond the next three years.

95k–110k extra construction workers needed by 2030	400,000 heat pumps targeted in homes by 2030	€13.8bn+ grid investment 2026–2030 (PR6)	–14% construction apprenticeship completions, 2024
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The Demand Ranking

Tier 1 — Electricians — especially high-voltage specialists

The single most cross-cutting trade, because it is hit by every driver at once: housing first-fix wiring, retrofit (heat-pump circuits and solar PV), and the grid and offshore buildout. The Commission for Regulation of Utilities approved a baseline of €13.8 billion in electricity-network investment for 2026–2030 (rising to €18.9 billion), an 80% increase on the prior cycle. At the specialist end the gap is acute — Wind Energy Ireland flags a severe domestic shortage in high-voltage and HVDC expertise, the precise skills needed to connect offshore wind to the grid. HV/HVDC is the highest-leverage skill on this list.

Tier 1 — Plumbers & heating engineers moving into heat-pump installation

Retrofit is the explicit driver. The National Residential Retrofit Plan 2026 carries €558 million targeting 70,000 homes, the heat-pump grant jumped to €12,500 for houses (nearly double the previous maximum), and there is a target of 400,000 heat pumps in homes by 2030. The demand signal is already visible: SEAI heat-pump applications rose 95% year-on-year in Q1 2026. Plumbers

who can deliver full heat-pump systems — including the radiator and pipework upgrades that unlock the higher grants — are scarce relative to demand.

Tier 1 — Insulation installers

Cavity wall, attic, and external wall insulation — the highest-volume retrofit trade and the precondition for everything else. SEAI is explicit that homes must be well insulated before a heat pump delivers value. Grant rates were raised specifically because installation costs rose, signalling sustained throughput.

Tier 2 — Core building trades

Bricklayers, carpenters and joiners, plasterers, plus groundworkers and crane and plant operators. Ireland is missing tens of thousands across these trades. Worth noting a structural shift: Modern Methods of Construction (modular and offsite) are being pushed to accelerate supply, creating factory-based construction roles alongside traditional site trades — though engineers caution these are not a shortcut around overall capacity.

Tier 2 — Wind turbine technicians & the offshore wind cluster

Ireland's offshore ambition (5GW by 2030, 37GW by 2050) is expected to create around 6,000 direct and 9,000 indirect jobs, spanning turbine technicians, ship and construction crew, electricians and drivers. The skills action plan identified 42 critical roles, 33 of which face significant recruitment challenges. Caveat: the 5GW-by-2030 target is now widely seen as slipping, so the offshore O&M boom is more a 2028-plus story — but training pipelines (GWO certification) are a bottleneck now.

Tier 2 — The “glue” vocational roles

BER assessors, retrofit coordinators, and One Stop Shop project managers. Not trades in the classic sense, but vocational, certification-based, and structurally undersupplied because the grant-driven retrofit model cannot function without them.

The Automation Angle

Automation displacement strengthens the case for trades rather than threatening it. The ESRI's April 2026 analysis found around 7% of current jobs could be lost in the short to medium term, but with a reversal of the historical pattern — this wave falls hardest on higher-paid, more highly educated, office-based workers. Clerical roles are the most exposed, with projected losses of about 18% for general and keyboard clerks.

By contrast, construction and manual trades are among the least affected, at roughly 0.6% for building trades. So automation is simultaneously protecting trade work from displacement and potentially freeing up labour from automatable office roles that could be retrained into these shortage areas — a redirection the National Training Fund is being positioned to support.

Caveats Worth Holding On To

- Demand is concentrated in Dublin and Cork, where mega-projects compete for the same scarce trades.

- Much of the gap is being met through immigration rather than domestic training — Ireland added 32 roles to its employment-permit system in 2026 across construction, healthcare, transport and agri-food — so wage inflation in these trades is likely to continue.
- Delivery is constrained by more than labour. Zoning, planning judicial reviews, and grid-connection timelines mean some demand is latent and will materialise on a lag.

Bottom Line by Objective

Career-changer: electrical with a high-voltage pathway is the strongest individual bet — cross-cutting demand, the highest skills premium, and the deepest specialist shortage.

Contractor scaling headcount: insulation and heat-pump installation capacity is the faster route to capturing grant-driven volume.

Training provider or policymaker: the apprenticeship-completion decline is the binding constraint; reversing it matters more than any single trade.

Figures drawn from Property Industry Ireland / Ibec, CIF, SOLAS National Skills Bulletin, SEAI, CRU (PR6), Wind Energy Ireland, the Offshore Wind Skills Action Plan, and the ESRI (2026). Quantitative targets and grant levels are current as of mid-2026 and subject to policy change.